

Bad AI journalism callout - The Verge's "AI's water and electricity use soars in 2025"

Posted by u/Human_certified • 0 points • 11 comments

****Bizarre comparison #1:****

"AI created as much carbon pollution this year as New York City"

This is not a lot.

NYC has 1/1000th of the global population. AI is a major global industry that is directly used by about 20% of the global population, and serves an even larger group indirectly.

We don't treat industries like car manufacturing, textile, transport, live entertainment, dining out, defense, sports, or anything else you can think of in the same way. AI is cleaner, more efficient, and more valuable per unit of energy spent.

Thank you, The Verge, for making this so very clear.

****Bizarre comparison #2:****

"AI guzzled up as much H2O as people consume globally in water bottles"

This is not a lot.

Most people in the world, it might shock you to know, drink water from the tap or other sources. Bottled water only represents about 5% of human water consumption. Human water consumption represents only 5% of global freshwater use.

So 0.25% of the freshwater withdrawals flow, unpolluted, through some data center. Once again, a tiny amount for a major, non-polluting industry.

Thank you, The Verge, for making this so very clear.

If you need to make such bizarre comparisons, I can only assume it's because you fully realize the actual numbers are unimpressive.

****Bonus language bias:****

According to the author, AI "guzzles" while humans "consume".

More accurately, though, AI "uses and returns unpolluted" while humans "piss away".

****Bonus use of go-to biased source:****

Alex de Vries-Gao is quoted, because of course he is. A non-expert on AI who has shown that he doesn't understand how GPUs work and previously overestimated their power consumption by 3-8x. But he's the person journalists trust, because they know what he's going to say.

Thank you, The Verge. At this point, nothing else you say can make me trust you. You truly represent excellence in unbiased science reporting.

Comments

u/Lemon0510 • 1 points • 2026-02-26 12:45 UTC

Which AI profiting company paid someone to post this

u/Jrmikulec • 1 points • 2025-12-20 03:08 UTC

AI uses this water and creates these emissions for NOTHING. That's why we don't compare it to other industries. AI doesn't do anything productive. If you find it makes you more productive, you are just useless.

u/EkansthePokemon • 1 points • 2026-01-02 23:31 UTC

it also does not use resources "unpolluted" as OP is claiming. as bad as the bottled water industry is, it doesn't drain underground aquifers dry like ai does. and with tech companies wanting to use the great lakes waterways for cooling, that would actually decrease available freshwater and unbalance the ecology of these areas

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2025-12-23 23:46 UTC

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u/SireEvalish • 1 points • 2025-12-19 05:48 UTC

The author's quick bio at the top of the article:

>Justine Calma is a senior science reporter covering energy and the environment with more than a decade of experience. She is also the host of Hell or High Water: When Disaster Hits Home, a podcast from Vox Media and Audible Originals.

This is what a decade of experience gets you. A almost completely bullshit article that shows a distinct lack of understanding of basic facts or figures.

I can't wait for The Verge to get bought by some VC fund and all their writers are replaced with ChatGPT. The quality can only go up at this point.

u/martianunlimited • 1 points • 2025-12-18 00:27 UTC

It's the Verge, seen their PC build guide? no technologist take them seriously....

u/Content-Bit9893 • 1 points • 2026-02-07 01:54 UTC

I had completely forgotten about this. Thanks for reminding me.

u/DaveG28 • 1 points • 2025-12-17 20:52 UTC

Directly used by 20% of the global population?

u/Human_certified • 2 points • 2025-12-17 22:57 UTC

The most recent statistic everyone quotes is 1.6 billion AI users out of 8 billion total humans. That includes the 900 million ChatGPT users, but presumably also a ton of people who don't realize what Gemini is, or Canva, or Apple's "genmoji" and all that. But they're all being served from the same data centers, so it seems fair to use that here.

u/captain_shane • 1 points • 2025-12-18 06:07 UTC

That includes google search ai overviews and people who use ai once per month. DAU's are far less than that.

u/lastberserker • 5 points • 2025-12-17 20:14 UTC

The article is remarkably dishonest in that it ignores the cost of producing plastics that are used for bottling water. That alone adds something like 30% to water usage and possibly matches AI datacenter energy usage.

On the sunny side of bad reporting, there is a chance that AI will displace Bitcoin mining, which is an absolutely useless scourge of energy waste.

u/Human_certified • 3 points • 2025-12-17 22:59 UTC

And all of journalism suddenly stopped caring about Bitcoin energy waste, despite it never having gone away and being literally entropy creation for the hell of it.

u/Revolutionary_Buddha • 6 points • 2025-12-17 20:07 UTC

Sensationalism sells.

When did the US become so anti technology? I think in a way its good for the world as it will allow other countries to catch up tbh.

u/ObjectOrientedBlob • 1 points • 2025-12-18 09:07 UTC

Being critical of Silicon Valley is not anti technology.

u/Popdmb • 1 points • 2025-12-19 08:56 UTC

Especially when the track record of its leaders is honestly bad. Take Mark Zuckerberg. Guy has not created a product on his own since 2004. The last few products he made were massive failures, most notably the metaverse. He was responsible for a massive potential loss for shareholders, even though the stock itself increased.

The 78 billion he spent on the Metaverse would have been much better spent on dividends.

Would encourage us all to be critical of Silicon Valley in this respect. Based on how the marketing alone does not meet the use case, the executives working at these companies have not found product-market fit despite massive investment.

u/One_Fuel3733 • 15 points • 2025-12-17 18:41 UTC

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u/Any-Drive8838 • 2 points • 2025-12-18 04:56 UTC

Yeah it happened. No more energy 🤖